



A FOOTBALL MATCH ON A NIPPY EVENING SERVED AS THE PERFECT *HORS D'OEUVRE* BEFORE THE NIGHT'S PARTIES

GIFT OF THE MAGI

FC Goa gave the **perfect Christmas gift** to its fans by beating Mohun Bagan Super Giant in a thrilling encounter.

With Christmas on the horizon, the coastal town of Margao was all decked out as posters went up for the Indian Super League (ISL) match on December 20. Goa, one of India's traditional football hubs, was hosting table topper and defending champion Mohun Bagan Super Giant.

At face value, it was a contest between a side coached by the Indian men's national team manager, Manolo Marquez, and the most expensive team in the league this season: money and form versus Goa's flair and passion for the beautiful game.

On another level, it was also an occasion for pre-Christmas festivities.

Big fish: FC Goa beat table topper Mohun Bagan Super Giant 2-1. ISL

Tourists from around the world thronged Goa's streets and beaches. A football match on a nippy evening served as the perfect *hors d'oeuvre* before the night's parties.

"We are a family of 17, and we got to know that there's a football match scheduled. So, all of us have come to have a good time," said Aasheim, who had travelled to Goa from Finland

Around the stadium, it felt as though the festival had already begun. Decorative paper stars, home team jerseys, and food stalls created a lively atmosphere, while some volunteers handed out free jerseys.

"The ticket prices for home games were initially reduced, and now the free jerseys only bring the community here closer to football," said Harsh Naik, one of the volunteers.

When the match kicked off, Goa took just 12 minutes to give its fans a reason to celebrate, as local boy Brison Fernandes scored the opening goal.

The cheers of over 13,000 fans briefly paused when a handful of travelling supporters found their voices. "Joy Mohun Bagan!" — they roared after Dimitrios Petratos scored an equaliser in the second half.

"We've come from Bengaluru and are part of the fan club Mariners Bangalore. We are about 20 people and we travel for several away fixtures, especially the ones along the coast, to Kerala and now, Goa," said Shubhankar Dasgupta, a lifelong Mohun Bagan fan.